LEAD ASPIRE DALLAS 2026

CONTOSO
THE AI GROWTH DILEMMA

Confidential-style customer account briefing | Student challenge edition

YOUR MISSION

You are part of a Microsoft account team asked to advise Contoso, a fictional professional services enterprise. Generative AI adoption is accelerating, operating costs are increasing, and leadership is debating whether to restrict usage. Your job is to understand the customer, assess the evidence, and propose a credible path forward.

Engagement snapshot	Current state
Customer	Contoso Global (fictional)
Industry	Professional services
Employees	12,000
Custom AI workloads	6 active workloads
Current monthly AI usage	27 million tokens
Current monthly Azure AI workload spend	$54,000
Executive concern	Consumption growth, unclear ROI, uneven governance

THE CUSTOMER REQUEST

From: Chief Information Officer, Contoso Global
To: Microsoft Account Team
Subject: Help us understand our AI usage and costs

Over the last six months, we have significantly expanded our use of generative AI across the organization. Consumption is now nearly three times our original forecast, and Finance has raised concerns about increasing operating costs.

We are considering introducing usage limits across the company. Before we make that decision, we would like Microsoft's recommendation. We need to understand what is driving this increase, which solutions are delivering value, and what we should do next.

02 / COMPANY BACKGROUND

Who is Contoso?

Contoso Global provides advisory, managed services, and customer operations support across North America and Latin America. Its growth strategy depends on productivity, faster service delivery, and improved customer experiences.

How Contoso arrived here

Six months ago: The CIO sponsored an AI acceleration initiative. A few centralized pilots were approved, and teams were encouraged to demonstrate quick wins.

Three months ago: Business units began launching their own AI assistants and experiments. Some projects were well managed; others lacked clear owners, baselines, or monitoring.

Today: Six custom AI workloads are active. Employee adoption is growing, but Finance cannot easily connect every dollar of AI spend to measurable outcomes.

Business objectives for the next two quarters

Priority	What success looks like
Customer experience	Sustain faster case resolution and customer satisfaction gains.
Employee productivity	Reduce repetitive work without disrupting employees.
Financial discipline	Make AI operating costs predictable and explainable.
Responsible scale	Introduce governance without stopping valuable innovation.
Decision quality	Prioritize workloads using usage, value, security, and feasibility.

What is NOT being requested

Contoso has not asked Microsoft to take control of its budget or arbitrarily divide a fixed funding pool. Contoso owns its spending decisions. The account team is expected to provide evidence-based recommendations and explain tradeoffs.

Guiding question

Is Contoso spending too much on AI, or is it failing to distinguish valuable growth from inefficient and unmanaged consumption?

03 / MICROSOFT ENVIRONMENT

Technology footprint

This is the assumed environment for the simulation. You may recommend optimizing existing capabilities before proposing additional tools or major rebuilds.

Technology / capability	Current state
Microsoft 365	12,000 employee licenses; enterprise collaboration and productivity.
Microsoft 365 Copilot	4,000 assigned licenses; productivity adoption measured separately from custom Azure AI token consumption.
Azure AI services	Six custom generative AI workloads using Azure-hosted model endpoints.
Microsoft Entra ID	Central identity platform; application-level access controls vary.
Microsoft Purview	Available for information governance; policies are unevenly adopted.
Azure Monitor	Partial monitoring; not all teams use consistent telemetry.
Azure Cost Management	Subscription spend visible, but tagging and chargeback are inconsistent.
Data platform	Internal knowledge repositories, CRM data, support tickets, and approved document stores.

Technical assumptions

The workloads use a mix of model capabilities. Some requests may be served by smaller or less expensive models, while other workflows require stronger reasoning. Prompt size, repeated requests, caching, retrieval design, and workflow routing can affect token usage and cost.

Security and governance boundaries

Customer data may include sensitive business and employee information. Teams must consider access controls, data classification, auditability, approved AI services, and the risks of unmanaged experimentation.

Important cost distinction

The $54,000 monthly figure in this case covers the six custom Azure AI workloads shown in the dashboard. Microsoft 365 Copilot seat licensing is not included in that token-based spend.

04 / STAKEHOLDER BRIEFING

Different leaders, different priorities

Your recommendation must be persuasive across the customer leadership team. Their goals overlap, but they do not always agree.

Stakeholder	What they care about	What they may challenge
CIO - Executive sponsor	Scale AI responsibly; keep innovation moving.	Will restrictions slow transformation?
CFO - Financial decision-maker	Predictable operating expense; credible ROI.	Where is the evidence that cost creates value?
CISO - Risk leader	Secure access, approved tools, clear accountability.	Are experiments exposing sensitive data?
VP Customer Support	Maintain service quality and productivity gains.	Will cost cuts damage customer outcomes?
VP People Operations	Employee adoption and HR workflow quality.	Why is HR Assistant adoption so low?
Head of Sales Operations	Seller productivity and workflow reliability.	Will changes disrupt a high-value assistant?

Stakeholder tension

The CFO favors a near-term cost reduction. The VP of Customer Support is concerned that broad usage caps would degrade a successful service workflow. The CISO wants tighter approval controls, while the CIO wants to preserve momentum.

Suggested discovery questions

Which outcomes are non-negotiable? What is the cost target and who approves exceptions? Which workloads have reliable benefit measures? Which security findings require immediate action? How much disruption can business owners tolerate?

Your team roles

Account Executive: customer goals and executive alignment. AI Specialist: AI use cases and model strategy. Solutions Engineer: feasibility and secure implementation. Customer Success Account Manager: adoption and realized value. Cloud Solutions Architect: architecture, reliability, scale, and cost optimization.

05 / USAGE AND SPENDING

AI consumption dashboard

The following values represent a consistent monthly snapshot. Figures are intentionally simplified for the learning exercise.

Metric	Current	Context
Monthly tokens	27.0M	Original plan: 10.0M (+170%)
Monthly custom AI spend	$54,000	Original plan: approx. $20,770 (+160%)
Employee adoption	68%	Up 32 percentage points over six months (scenario assumption)
Active workloads	6	Three introduced during recent expansion

Workload	Tokens/mo	Cost/mo	Adoption	Value
Customer Support AI	10.2M	$20,000	91%	High
Sales Assistant	4.1M	$8,000	82%	High
Marketing Content AI	5.0M	$10,000	71%	Medium
HR Assistant	2.8M	$6,000	23%	Low
Internal Knowledge Bot	3.5M	$7,000	64%	Unknown
AI Experiments	1.4M	$3,000	N/A	Unknown
TOTAL	27.0M	$54,000	-	-

How to interpret the numbers

High consumption is not automatically waste. A workload may cost more because it is used heavily and delivers meaningful outcomes. Conversely, a low-cost experiment can still be risky if it lacks approval or data controls.

Data quality note

Some business value labels are preliminary management assessments, not audited ROI calculations. Students should explicitly identify where evidence is insufficient.

06 / WORKLOAD INTELLIGENCE

What is happening inside the workloads?

Customer Support AI - high value

Automates answers and supports service agents. Average resolution time decreased 31%, customer satisfaction increased 8%, and support backlog decreased 24%. Complex cases currently use a premium-capability model. Leadership wants to preserve these gains.

Sales Assistant - high value

Summarizes account activity and prepares seller briefings. Adoption is strong at 82%. Sales Operations reports faster preparation time, but formal revenue attribution remains incomplete.

Marketing Content AI - medium value

Generates first drafts and campaign variations. Usage is growing, but multiple teams run similar prompts repeatedly and have not standardized review or reuse patterns.

HR Assistant - low value

Handles internal policy questions. Only 23% of intended employees use it. Answers sometimes duplicate existing HR resources, and the experience has not been optimized for common requests.

Internal Knowledge Bot - unknown value

Searches internal documents. Employees use it, but the team has not defined a consistent outcome measure. Some responses are long and may retrieve more context than needed.

AI Experiments - unknown value and governance concern

Several sandbox projects are operating without a standardized approval process. Ownership is inconsistent; some teams have tested external tools, and data classification is incomplete.

Evidence gaps students should recognize

Per-request cost, model routing, prompt lengths, latency, repeated queries, business outcome baselines, data sensitivity, and projected future demand are not fully documented. Reasonable recommendations may include targeted investigation before irreversible changes.

07 / CUSTOMER CONSTRAINTS

What limits the recommendation?

Constraint	Customer position
Financial target	CFO prefers custom Azure AI workload spend of $40,000-$45,000 per month within the next quarter. This is a target, not a hard budget Microsoft controls.
Value protection	Customer Support AI service gains must not be materially degraded.
Implementation	Near-term actions should begin within 30 days; larger improvements may take 60-90 days.
Governance	Unapproved experimentation and sensitive-data exposure require attention.
Operations	Business owners must approve significant workflow changes.
Measurement	The CIO expects a dashboard of spend, adoption, business outcomes, and risks.

Possible tradeoffs

A broad token cap might reduce spend quickly but disrupt high-value workloads. A technical optimization may save money while preserving service, but requires testing. Consolidating overlapping tools could help, but might face adoption and change-management barriers.

What a credible recommendation includes

A clear business problem; prioritized opportunities; specific actions and owners; likely benefits and risks; assumptions; measures of success; and a phased implementation plan.

No single correct answer

Judges will value defensible reasoning and customer alignment, not a predetermined combination of actions. Quantitative savings estimates should be labeled as assumptions unless the case provides evidence to calculate them.

08 / YOUR ENGAGEMENT

Your Microsoft account team mission

You have been invited to prepare a recommendation for Contoso leadership. Work as a team, use the portal and optional guides, and create a concise executive presentation.

The four challenge phases

Phase	Expected work
01 - Discover	Understand the CIO request, company background, stakeholder goals, and workload evidence. Identify missing information.
02 - Strategize	Diagnose the underlying problems, compare options, prioritize recommendations, and seek mentor feedback.
03 - Design Your Solution	Describe the target approach, implementation steps, safeguards, ownership, and measures of success. A working prototype is not required.
04 - Pitch & Submit	Submit a concise executive recommendation that can be presented to a simulated customer panel.

Suggested presentation structure

1. What we heard from Contoso. 2. What the evidence reveals. 3. Our recommended actions and why. 4. Expected impact, risks, and assumptions. 5. A phased plan with measures of success.

Use your Microsoft team roles

All five perspectives should inform the final solution. Students may share responsibilities if the team has fewer than five members. You do not need to create a separate artifact for every role.

Reference rules

This briefing is the official source of case facts. The portal should display the same numbers and statements. Optional resource PDFs teach professional skills but are not mandatory assignments. Mentors may help you think critically; they should not provide a prewritten solution.

LEAD ASPIRE

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Fictional simulation created for educational use at LEAD Aspire Dallas 2026. This document does not represent an actual Microsoft customer engagement.